as if singing of His glory and power. Would we succeed with the Agni launch tomorrow? This question was foremost in al our minds, but none of us was wil ing to break the spel cast by the beautiful moonlit night. Breaking a long silence, the Defence Minister final y asked me, “Kalam! what would you like me to do to celebrate the Agni success tomorrow?” It was a simple question, to which I could not think of an answer immediately. What did I want? What was it that I did not have? What could make me happier? And then I found the answer. “We need 100,000 saplings to plant at RCI,” I said. His face lit up with a friendly glow. “You are buying the blessings of Mother Earth for Agni,” Defence Minister KC Pant quipped. “We wil succeed tomorrow”, he predicted.

The next day Agni took off at 0710 hrs. It was a perfect launch. The missile fol owed a textbook trajectory. Al flight parameters were met. It was like waking up to a beautiful morning from a nightmarish sleep. We had reached the launch pad after five years of continuous work at multiple work centres. We had lived through the ordeal of a series of snags in the last five weeks. We had survived pressure from everywhere to stop the whole thing. But we did it at last! It was one of the greatest moments of my life. A mere